

# Oven Hash Browns — The Sheet-Pan Slab

Shatter-crisp both faces, tender inside, barely hands-on — one slab feeds the crew. The whole game is getting the water out before it hits the oven.

Yield: 12 squares (half-sheet)    Active: 25 min    Total: 1 hr    Oven: 230°C (450°F)    Done: deep gold

**WHERE IT WAS BORN**  
American diners — “hashed brown potatoes” defined by Maria Parloa, 1888 (*Kitchen Companion*); the name from French *hacher*, to chop. Europe’s older cousin: Bernese *rösti*, 17th c.

**EATEN, AUTHENTICALLY**  
The diner breakfast plate — eggs, bacon, toast; in Switzerland a meal in itself, *rösti* under fried eggs or *Zürcher Geschnetzeltes*.

**HOW IT’S USED NOW**  
A global breakfast staple; the same grated-potato base becomes *rösti*, latkes, the skillet cake — crust over a tender middle, topped any way.

## INGREDIENTS

12 SQUARES · WEIGHT

|                                                     |                      |
|-----------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| Russet / Maris Piper, peeled ( <i>high-starch</i> ) | 2000g<br>4 lb 6.5 oz |
| Fine sea salt ( <i>for the squeeze</i> )            | 12g<br>2 tsp         |
| Cornstarch                                          | 30g<br>⅓ cup         |
| Clarified butter / oil ( <i>toss</i> )              | 60g<br>⅓ cup         |
| Oil, for the hot pan                                | 40g<br>2⅞ tbsp       |
| Black pepper + <i>opt. onion, paprika</i>           | —                    |

**THE RATIO — OF THE SQUEEZED POTATO**  
**Cornstarch 2% · Fat 4% (toss)**, and squeeze out **~30% of the grated weight in water** first. Dryness is the whole game — weigh it if unsure.

**Kit:** half-sheet pan · food processor (grating disc) · box grater · clean towel · scale · sturdy spatula

## METHOD

- Preheat hard.** Oven **230°C (450°F)** with the sheet pan *inside*.

*A preheated steel pan crisps the base by conduction, like a skillet; the oven frees your hands and browns the top. — McGee 2004*
- Grate & rinse.** Grate 2000g potato (processor disc). Rinse in cold water until it runs clear; drain.

*Rinsing removes loose surface starch that turns gummy; the bound starch inside still holds it together. — López-Alt*
- Salt, rest, squeeze BONE-DRY.** Toss with 12g salt, stand 10 min, squeeze hard in a towel (in batches). Target ~30% lighter.

*Salt pulls water by osmosis; the squeeze removes the rest. Water → steam → soggy. This step makes or breaks it. — McGee; López-Alt*
- Coat.** Toss dry potato with 30g cornstarch, 60g melted fat, pepper (+ onion/paprika).

*A thin cornstarch film gelatinises then dehydrates into a glassy, shatter-crisp shell. — López-Alt; Modernist*
- Press on the hot pan.** Pull pan, add 40g oil + swirl, spread an even ~1.5 cm layer and **press firm**. It should sizzle.
- Bake, flip once.** ~20 min to deep-gold base, flip the slab in sections, ~12–15 min more to crisp both sides.

**Done:** deep golden-brown, lacy crisp edges, tender inside. **Season the hot crust, cut 12 squares, serve at once** — crisp fades as it sits.

**Efficiency & service** — one slab, not patties: grate in the processor, one squeeze, one press, one flip. Par-bake to pale-gold ahead, then finish-crisp to order — minutes to plate across a staggered crew breakfast.

**ONE POTATO, TWO DISHES — BERNESE RÖSTI**  
Same squeezed, dry potato — but skip the cornstarch and bake. Melt **butter** in a hot heavy skillet, press the potato into a **cake**, crisp covered **8 min**, slide onto a plate and **invert back** to crisp the second face. *The farmhouse original — no oven, one pan.*

**ELEVATION**

**TIER 1 — NO EXTRA TIME**

- Smoked paprika + pepper** — in the toss
- Grated onion** — squeezed dry, folded in
- Parmesan lid** — 40g, last 5 min

**TIER 2 — WORTH IT**

- Duck fat** — swap the toss fat
- Gruyère rösti** — 150g folded through
- Everything-bagel crust** — scattered on top

**TIER 3 — SERVICE**

- Fried egg + crème fraîche**
- Brown-butter** toss fat
- Confit-then-crisp** for guest plating

## TROUBLESHOOT

|                 |                                                                           |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Gummy / gluey   | Surface starch left in → rinse till water runs clear                      |
| Pale, steamed   | Too wet / pan cold → squeeze harder; preheat fully                        |
| Sticks & tears  | Not enough hot oil → swirl 40g in first; let the base set before flipping |
| Crisp then soft | Held too long → serve at once; re-crisp hot, uncovered                    |

## CHARTER PREP & STORAGE

|                        |                                                          |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Best route</b>      | Par-bake the slab pale-gold ahead; finish-crisp to order |
| <b>Squeezed potato</b> | Use promptly — toss with the fat to slow browning        |
| <b>Par-baked slab</b>  | 1 day fridge; re-crisp 230°C                             |
| <b>Frozen</b>          | 1 mo par-baked; crisp from frozen at 230°C               |
| <b>Never</b>           | Cover or hold hot — steam kills the crust                |